

Why is chat gpt / AI bad for the environment?

Posted by u/ApplicationOwn9636 • 0 points • 7 comments

Can someone explain how asking chat gpt is bad for environment?

Comments

u/selene_666 • 1 points • 2025-07-07 23:23 UTC

It takes a lot of computing power, which both uses up a lot of electricity and requires a lot of computer chips.

Electricity in the US is still largely produced by burning coal and other fossil fuels. Computer chips are made of rare minerals that had to be mined, and despite using a ton of water the manufacturing process mostly happens in Arizona.

Furthermore, large spikes in demand for electricity are bad for the power grid. They can cause blackouts and power surges to nearby homes, and destabilize the grid as a whole.

u/Suitable-Ad-6711 • 1 points • 2025-07-07 23:17 UTC

According to chatgpt:

AI is bad for the environment mainly because training and running large AI models consumes huge amounts of electricity, often sourced from fossil fuels. Data centers that power AI require constant cooling and infrastructure, adding to carbon emissions. The demand for specialized hardware like GPUs contributes to electronic waste and resource extraction. As AI use grows, so does its energy footprint, sometimes outpacing efforts to make it greener. Without sustainable practices, AI could significantly worsen climate change impacts.

u/jacobissimus • 1 points • 2025-07-07 23:13 UTC

It's the scale of computational resources involved. Any server farm is burning energy and contributing to climate change, but training LLMs is just such another level than normal search engines

u/ApplicationOwn9636 • 1 points • 2025-07-07 23:14 UTC

Thank you that makes sense!

u/archpaw • 2 points • 2025-07-07 23:12 UTC

It uses a lot of power to train and run, and also water. Each time it's not much, but it adds up. Imagine you used ChatGPT ten times a day for a year. You'd end up using about as much water and electricity as it takes to make a whole cheeseburger. (I did the math a while ago and don't have it on me, but if

you want I can work it out again.)

Seriously though, [it's not bad for the environment](andymasley.substack.com/p/a-cheat-sheet-for-conversations-about). Or at least, not worse than a bunch of other things that aren't significant enough for us to care about. Sometimes people worry about electricity bills. Anything that uses so little electricity that they give it out for free is obviously going to have much less environmental impact.

u/ApplicationOwn9636 • 1 points • 2025-07-07 23:08 UTC

To add to my initial question I don't really understand how it's different than using a search engine.

u/archpawm • 2 points • 2025-07-07 23:16 UTC

It's supposed to use about ten times as much power. Though nobody's clear on exactly how much it uses, and it's likely they've been trying to make more power-efficient models.